

VOICE-LEADING RULE REVIEW AND CORRECTION GUIDE

Score: Prelude and Fugue for Recorders in G - Full score - 01 Fugue.musicxml

SUMMARY STATISTICS

Total violations analyzed: 75

Violation counts (by rule number as displayed in PDF legend):

- Rule 1 - Parallel P5ths: 8
- Rule 2 - Parallel octaves: 10
- Rule 3 - Parallel unisons: 1
- Rule 4 - Direct octaves: 0
- Rule 5 - Direct 5ths: 0
- Rule 6 - Voice crossing: 26
- Rule 7 - Augmented 2nd: 0
- Rule 8 - Melodic tritone: 1
- Rule 9 - Large leap: 8
- Rule 10 - Leading tone unresolved: 21

RULE 1: PARALLEL PERFECT FIFTHS (8 violations)

THE RULE:

Two voices in similar motion should not move consecutively from one perfect fifth to another.

WHY IT MATTERS:

- Parallel perfect intervals undermine voice independence by making two lines sound as one unit.
- This is the most fundamental voice-leading prohibition in baroque counterpoint.
- Avoiding parallels ensures each voice maintains its own identity and contour.

WHEN FLAGGED:

The analyzer detects both voices moving in the same direction into P5 !' P5.

EXAMPLES FROM THIS SCORE:

- m.4 beat 2: Soprano & Alto: B-E !' A-D
- m.11 beat 3: Soprano & Tenor: A-D !' G-C
- m.32 beat 2: Alto & Bass: A-D !' B-E

WHY IT MAY STILL BE MUSICAL:

- Sequential patterns sometimes generate parallel fifths as a stylistic choice.
- In fast-moving passages, brief parallels may be less noticeable.
- Instrumental ensembles tolerate parallels better than vocal writing.

CORRECTION OPTIONS (prioritized):

1. BEST: Change one arriving note by step to produce a 6th or 3rd instead.
2. Introduce contrary or oblique motion in one voice between the two chords.
3. Break the sequence for one event to avoid the parallel.

RULE 2: PARALLEL OCTAVES (10 violations)

THE RULE:

Two voices in similar motion should not move consecutively from one perfect octave to another.

WHY IT MATTERS:

- Parallel octaves eliminate all harmonic distinction between two voices.
- They sound like a single doubling rather than two independent lines.
- This is second only to parallel fifths in severity of voice-leading violation.

WHEN FLAGGED:

The analyzer detects both voices moving in the same direction into P8 !' P8.

EXAMPLES FROM THIS SCORE:

- m.6 beat 2: Soprano & Tenor: A-A !' G-G
- m.7 beat 3: Soprano & Bass: A-A !' G-G
- m.21 beat 1: Alto & Bass: G-G !' A-A

WHY IT MAY STILL BE MUSICAL:

- In ensemble doubling (especially reinforcement of outer voices), parallel octaves are accepted.
- Thicker textures can support more parallel motion than sparse counterpoint.
- But in pedagogical writing, they should be avoided.

CORRECTION OPTIONS (prioritized):

1. BEST: Alter one voice to arrive at a 10th or 6th instead of an octave.
2. Use contrary motion in one outer voice into the second sonority.
3. Reassign one note to a nearby chord tone that avoids the octave.

RULE 3: PARALLEL UNISONS (1 violation)

THE RULE:

Two voices should not arrive on unison multiple consecutive times.

WHY IT MATTERS:

- Repeated unison motion merges lines completely and destroys voice independence.
- While unison arrivals can occur occasionally, sustained unison motion is poor counterpoint.
- This is less common in well-written baroque music than in arrangements or reductions.

WHEN FLAGGED:

The analyzer detects both voices arriving on the same pitch in consecutive measures/attacks.

EXAMPLES FROM THIS SCORE:

- m.25 beat 1: Alto & Bass unison on A

WHY IT MAY STILL BE MUSICAL:

- In arrangements, deliberate doubling at the unison can be a stylistic choice.
- With certain voices removed from the full score, unison chains may be incidental.
- A single unison arrival is not a violation; repeated unison motion is.

CORRECTION OPTIONS (prioritized):

1. Convert one member of the pair to a 3rd, 6th, or other consonance.
2. Keep occasional unison arrivals but avoid repeated consecutive motion.
3. Offset one voice rhythmically (suspension, anticipation) to break the chain.

RULE 4: DIRECT OCTAVES (0 violations)

THE RULE:

Outer voices should not move in similar motion into a perfect octave with an upward leap in the soprano.

WHY IT MATTERS:

- Direct fifths/octaves (also called "hidden" intervals) create the effect of parallel motion even without consecutive perfect intervals.
- In outer voices especially, this weakens the independence and clarity of the counterpoint.
- Avoiding them strengthens voice leading in strict species counterpoint.

WHEN FLAGGED:

The analyzer detects similar motion into a perfect octave (P8) with soprano jumping more than a step.

WHY IT MAY STILL BE MUSICAL:

- Direct motions into perfect intervals are less strict than actual parallel motions.
- With soprano stepwise motion, the "hidden" effect is greatly reduced.
- In instrumental writing and faster textures, they are often acceptable.

CORRECTION OPTIONS (prioritized):

1. Use stepwise motion in the soprano instead of a leap.
2. Introduce contrary motion in one of the outer voices.
3. Arrive at an interval other than a perfect octave.

RULE 5: DIRECT 5THS (0 violations)

THE RULE:

Outer voices should not move in similar motion into a perfect fifth with an upward leap in the soprano.

WHY IT MATTERS:

- Similar to direct octaves, direct fifths weaken outer voice independence.
- The effect is less severe than direct octaves but still discouraged in strict writing.
- Clear counterpoint benefits from avoiding these implicit parallels.

WHEN FLAGGED:

The analyzer detects similar motion into a perfect fifth (P5) with soprano jumping more than a step.

WHY IT MAY STILL BE MUSICAL:

- Direct fifths are stylistically acceptable in many contexts, especially with soprano stepwise motion.
- In faster harmonic movement and instrumental texture, they are common.
- The rule is less strict than those for actual parallel intervals.

CORRECTION OPTIONS (prioritized):

1. Use stepwise motion in the soprano instead of a leap.
2. Introduce contrary motion in one of the outer voices.
3. Arrive at an interval other than a perfect fifth.

RULE 6: VOICE CROSSING (26 violations)

THE RULE:

Each voice should remain within its proper register. Lower voices should generally not rise above higher voices.

WHY IT MATTERS:

- Voice crossing blurs the registral hierarchy and confuses which line is which.
- Clear voice layering (Soprano > Alto > Tenor > Bass) helps the listener track lines.
- Crossing can make the ensemble sound muddled or unbalanced.

WHEN FLAGGED:

The analyzer detects a lower voice briefly moving above a higher voice.

(Unison landings and intentional pitch swaps are already filtered out.)

EXAMPLES FROM THIS SCORE:

- m.9 beat 1: Alto crosses Tenor (G vs C)
- m.16 beat 2: Alto crosses Tenor (E vs C#)
- m.38 beat 1: Alto crosses Tenor (B vs D)

WHY IT MAY STILL BE MUSICAL:

- Imitative passages can tolerate brief crossings when subjects interweave.
- A momentary crossing for color or textural contrast can be effective.
- If the crossing is fast and unaccented, it may go unnoticed.

CORRECTION OPTIONS (prioritized):

1. Keep voices in proper register: raise the lower voice or lower the higher voice.
2. When lines converge, use contrary motion or rests to maintain separation.
3. Re-octave one note to restore vertical order without changing harmony.

RULE 7: AUGMENTED 2ND (0 violations)

THE RULE:

A single voice should not leap by an augmented 2nd (three semitones), as this interval sounds awkward in melody.

WHY IT MATTERS:

- The augmented 2nd is an unusual melodic interval that often signals harmonic instability.
- It is characteristic of harmonic minor and exotic scales but sounds jarring in major-key writing.
- Avoiding it keeps melodic lines smooth and idiomatic to common-practice style.

WHEN FLAGGED:

The analyzer detects a melodic augmented 2nd in a single voice.

WHY IT MAY STILL BE MUSICAL:

- In harmonic minor contexts, augmented 2nds are idiomatic and expected.
- In certain period styles and exotic harmonic contexts, they are acceptable.
- Fast ornamental passages may make them less noticeable.

CORRECTION OPTIONS (prioritized):

1. BEST: Fill the span with passing notes instead of direct leap.
2. Redirect one endpoint to avoid the augmented 2nd interval.
3. Change harmonic context to make the interval more idiomatic.

RULE 8: MELODIC TRITONE (1 violation)

THE RULE:

A single voice should not leap directly by tritone (augmented 4th or diminished 5th).

WHY IT MATTERS:

- The tritone is historically considered the "diabolus in musica" (devil in music).
- It sounds harsh when leaped directly without preparation or resolution.
- Filling the tritone by step is the standard correction.

WHEN FLAGGED:

The analyzer detects a tritone interval (6 semitones) in melodic motion within a single voice.

EXAMPLES FROM THIS SCORE:

- m.16 beat 1.5: Bass: C# !' G

WHY IT MAY STILL BE MUSICAL:

- In harmonic minor and sequential contexts, tritone leaps can be idiomatic.
- Fast harmonic movement can make tritone outlines less noticeable.
- The tritone outline may be justified by harmonic function.

CORRECTION OPTIONS (prioritized):

1. BEST: Fill the span with passing notes instead of direct leap.
2. Redirect one endpoint to the nearest chord tone (producing a 4th or 3rd).
3. Keep the harmonic target but approach/leave by stepwise motion.

RULE 9: LARGE LEAP (>=10 semitones) (8 violations)

THE RULE:

When a single voice leaps more than an octave, it should be followed by stepwise motion in the opposite direction.

WHY IT MATTERS:

- Large leaps are difficult to sing and disorient the listener.
- Recovering by stepwise opposite motion creates a smooth contour and fills the skip.
- This principle applies especially to vocal lines but is useful for all writing.

WHEN FLAGGED:

The analyzer detects a leap of 10+ semitones (major 7th or larger).

EXAMPLES FROM THIS SCORE:

- m.9 beat 1: Alto: F# !' G (leap of 11 semitones)
- m.30 beat 1: Alto: A !' G (leap of 14 semitones)
- m.32 beat 1: Bass: D !' C (leap of 14 semitones)

WHY IT MAY STILL BE MUSICAL:

- Instrumental music can support larger leaps than vocal writing.
- Octave transfers are expressive if balanced by good phrase contour.
- Fast passage work can make large leaps less perceptually jarring.

CORRECTION OPTIONS (prioritized):

1. Replace the large leap with two smaller intervals via passing notes.
2. Keep the leap but ensure stepwise recovery in the opposite direction.
3. Redistribute the octave transfer to another voice with better tessitura.

RULE 10: LEADING TONE UNRESOLVED (21 violations)

THE RULE:

The leading tone (scale degree 7) should resolve up by semitone to the tonic.

In G major: F# must resolve to G, ideally in the same voice and on accented beats.

WHY IT MATTERS:

- The leading tone has strong harmonic gravity toward the tonic in tonal music.
- This tendency creates smooth, logical voice leading and reinforces tonal function.
- Violating this weakens tonal clarity and can make cadences sound uncertain.

WHEN FLAGGED:

The analyzer detects F# moving to any pitch other than G (E, A, C#, B, D, etc.)

EXAMPLES FROM THIS SCORE:

- m.3 beat 4: Alto: F# !' E
- m.7 beat 2: Soprano: F# !' A
- m.21 beat 2: Alto: F# !' C#

WHY IT MAY STILL BE MUSICAL:

- In fugues, inner voice leading often prioritizes independence over tendency resolution.
- Passing tones and sequences can legitimately defer or avoid immediate resolution.
- If F# appears on a weak beat in a non-structural context, resolution is less critical.

CORRECTION OPTIONS (prioritized):

1. PREFERRED: Move F# to G in the next note of the same voice.
2. If harmonic function prevents direct resolution, eventually move F# to G by step.
3. If F# is passing or ornamental, consider re-notating it as a lower voice note.

RECOMMENDED CORRECTION WORKFLOW

STEP 1: PRIORITY FIXES (most important for pedagogical correctness)

- o Rule 1: Parallel Perfect Fifths – Remove or convert to 6ths/3rds
- o Rule 2: Parallel Octaves – Remove or convert to 10ths/6ths

STEP 2: SECONDARY FIXES (important for harmonic clarity)

- o Rule 10: Leading Tone Unresolved – Ensure F# !' G at major cadence points
- o Rule 6: Voice Crossing – Maintain clear voice register hierarchy

STEP 3: LINE OPTIMIZATION (refine melodic shape)

- o Rule 9: Large Leaps – Add passing notes or ensure opposite stepwise recovery
- o Rule 8: Melodic Tritone – Fill tritone outline with passing motion

STEP 4: DISCRETIONARY (musical judgment call)

- o Rule 3: Parallel Unisons – Acceptable in imitative writing if intentional
- o Rules 4-5: Direct intervals – Less critical than actual parallel motion

QUICK TRIAGE:

Focus on measures 3-7, 16, 21, 32, and 37 first.

These contain most structural violations (parallel P5ths/P8ves and unresolved LT).

End of review.